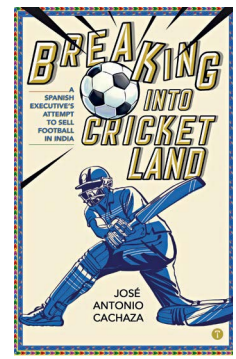


Q. Would you say you succeeded?
Mostly, yes. It was a largely successful operation; however, some projects didn't turn out exactly as planned, and others never left the drawing board. In the book, I discuss our successes, but I also make a point of addressing those initiatives that fell short or remained unrealised.

Q. Why does cricket have such a stranglehold on the Indian imagination? Does football even stand a chance?
Cricket functions in India much like football does in Spain: it is an integral part of the collective mindset. Consequently, it occupies almost the entire media landscape and attracts 90 per cent of all sports investment. That said, football is carving out its space as India's second sport. Beyond its traditional strongholds in Bengal, Goa, Kerala and the Northeast, it is growing rapidly among the youth in metropolitan areas.



Q. What did you learn about India during your seven-year stint here?
I learned that I will never learn enough. I also discovered that beneath the apparent chaos, there is always a deeper, underlying order.

Q. Was there something about India that infuriated you?
As I say in the introduction of the book, the total lack of respect for a proper queue in India was the one thing that always got to me.

—with Amit Dixit

MARATHON ▼

CATCH ME IF YOU CAN

Sawan Barwal **has broken a 48-year-old record to become India's fastest marathoner**

Talent hunts are known to unearth gems. One such programme discovered India's fastest marathoner, Sawan Barwal. On April 12, the 28-year-old smashed Indian athletics' longest-standing men's national record at the NN Marathon Rotterdam in the Netherlands. Barwal clocked 2 hours, 11 minutes, 58 seconds (2.11.58) to go under Shivnath Singh's time (2.12.00) from 1978 and meet the qualifying mark for the Asian Games later this year. This was also the first time Barwal ran a competitive marathon.

RUNNING HIS FIRST COMPETITIVE MARATHON, BARWAL CLOCKED 2 HOURS, 11 MINUTES, 58 SECONDS TO GO UNDER SHIVNATH SINGH'S 2.12.00 FROM 1978

"Right after the 2022 Asian Games, I first considered running the marathon at the next edition. I wanted to start training for the distance last year, but it was only possible in January as I was injured," says Barwal.

During his early days, he played everything from badminton and volleyball to kho-kho and kabaddi. But he was gradually developing endurance while trotting up and down the slopes around his hometown of Jogindernagar in Himachal Pradesh. In 2017, his fearless running made an instant impact on army scouts who were looking for junior talents. Over the next two years, Barwal trained at the Army Sports Institute in Pune.

After joining the Indian Army, he ran every distance from 1,500m on track to 25km road races. Last year, he set new National Games records in the 5,000m and 10,000m events. Then, earlier this year, the Reliance Foundation athlete started working towards his longest distance yet.

In Rotterdam, Barwal targeted a sub-2.10 timing. At the 40km mark (2.03.40), it seemed on track until he stumbled over the remaining distance. "I had thrown some water on my head, then a cold breeze hit me. My entire face froze. I just couldn't think straight, blacked out and fell a couple of times before the finish," he recalls.

Though he was told about the record, Barwal was distraught, well aware that he could have been a lot faster. It wasn't until he had a word with his partner, Shabnam, that he made peace with the result. "She explained how no runner had managed to better the mark in 48 years. And how I should enjoy the moment, for there would be plenty of opportunities," he says. ■

—Shail Desai